

Champion comeback:

Back from injury, Aslam Inamdar — the skipper who powered Puneri Paltan to the PKL 10 title — is ready to lead from the front once again. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

“The old water is flowing away, making way for fresh water. Many youngsters are waiting to take over. We saw the likes of Devank and Ayan last season, but there are plenty more eager to prove themselves. We may see a few more of them own that stage this season,” Rao says.

The auction has mirrored this generational shift. Teams could, for the first time, retain players for two seasons instead of one — a small but important nod to stability.

“Long-term contracts, trading windows, player policies, exit clauses for teams to also be secure should all be on the table,” U Mumba CEO Suhail Chandokh had said after the last edition. The league appears to be moving that way.”

Longevity is the best term to be used here. Players sticking with teams for a longer time is good for the league in the long run. Even now, there are thousands who associate Rahul Chaudhari with Telugu Titans. That bonding is required and advantageous for the player as much as it is for the team,” Rao explains.

Coaching rosters have also been reshuffled. For the first time in PKL history, Randhir Singh Sehrawat — who led Bengaluru Bulls to the Season 6 title — finds himself without a team. Ram Mehar Singh, who masterminded Patna Pirates’ early

THE NEW FORMAT INCREASES THE INCENTIVE TO FINISH HIGHER ON THE TABLE, RATHER THAN SIMPLY SNEAKING INTO THE KNOCKOUTS AND COASTING

dominance, is also absent.

In their place, younger coaches and former greats have been entrusted: Ajay Thakur with Puneri Paltan, Anup Kumar at the Pirates, Anil Chaprana back with U Mumba, and Joginder Narwal continuing at Dabang Delhi.